

Chapter 20_1: Ruyan Tower

But she had no time to be surprised and could only take advantage of the fact that the power hadn't yet dissipated to change her hands. In an instant, the pink light almost filled the entire ravine, colliding with that palm-shaped turbid qi and forming circular air currents that scattered with a roar.

The rumbling sound echoed as many fragments of rock rolled down from both sides of the cliff walls. Chu Qingqiu beside her suddenly pressed down on her head, shielding her from those falling stones.

"It's about to go into a rage, get up quickly," Chu Qingqiu said in a low voice. She seemed to disregard the wound on her chest as she tried to stand, but Ning Fuyi quickly pulled her back.

Just from that one pull, her palm was covered with blood. Ning Fuyi's heart jumped violently.

However, the demon beast didn't give them time to worry about injuries. After the air currents disappeared, the demon beast seemed very dissatisfied that its attack had been blocked. It suddenly roared twice, then raised its front hooves - two iron-like feet gleaming with luster crashed down toward the ground like giant stones.

Ning Fuyi was about to use the same trick again when a furry figure suddenly darted out in front of her. Her vision immediately went black as she reached out to catch it back.

That figure was Ping'an. It had somehow awakened and for some reason rushed forward.

Fear surged from Ning Fuyi's heart to her limbs. However, Chu Qingqiu held her arm tightly, forcing her to watch helplessly as those hooves dozens of times larger than Ping'an came crashing down like meteors.

Then they steadily stopped above the little dog's head.

The hand holding Ning Fuyi suddenly released, and she staggered two steps before steadying herself, staring intently at the scene before her.

Ping'an seemed oblivious to the hooves above, sometimes turning in circles, sometimes crouching down, sometimes turning around to wag its tail at the sky.

The demon beast also stood frozen in place. After a very long time, it suddenly pulled its feet back to its chest. Its terrifying large face lowered down, seemingly tilting its head to identify what the furry little fool beneath its feet was.

Ning Fuyi didn't dare breathe. She couldn't help turning back to look at Chu Qingqiu - both their eyes showed shock.

Ping'an finished turning in circles and suddenly started barking at the demon beast.

"Mother," Chu Qingqiu suddenly spoke.

Ning Fuyi was even more confused. Her eye twitched as she turned and said, "Hm?"

But she received an icy glare from Chu Qingqiu in return.

"I said, it's calling for its mother," Chu Qingqiu covered her wound, struggling to repeat herself.

The level of shock this sentence brought to Ning Fuyi was no less than if Chu Qingqiu had told her that rebirth was actually an illusion. Ning Fuyi's mouth fell open as she looked at Ping'an again - that silly dog was still wagging its tail, so eager it seemed ready to pull its black and white tail out by the roots.

"You can understand dog barking?" Ning Fuyi blurted out.

Chu Qingqiu's brow furrowed deeper, whether from anger or pain. She simply pressed both hands against her wound and panted, "Simple beast language."

Even more shocking was that the demon beast slowly lowered its hooves, its ugly head dropping even lower, using the two large black holes on its face to sniff Ping'an's head.

The two species differed too greatly in size, making this scene quite bizarre, with no trace of warmth to be seen.

Ping'an stuck out its tongue to lick the demon beast's wounded and bleeding nostril. With each lick, Ning Fuyi's heart trembled along with it.

"This is bad, it's getting dark," Chu Qingqiu suddenly said. As if responding to her words, black turbid qi surged from all directions, sealing off the sky above that was like a thin line. What followed was a desperate sense of suffocation that gradually enveloped people's hearts.

Ning Fuyi knew the terrifying nature of the ghost eye. Every night, turbid qi filled the ravine, devouring all living things within, absorbing their spiritual intelligence. After one night, even a great immortal would lose their sanity and remain forever at the bottom of this valley.

The demon beast also suddenly raised its head to look toward the distant sky. It seemed to become restless, pacing in place and emitting continuous hissing sounds.

"What does it want to do?" Ning Fuyi muttered to herself. She suddenly stood up, shielding herself from the wind and dust with her hands, looking up at the sky along with the demon beast.

The demon beast's cries became more mournful. It suddenly lowered its head to take Ping'an in its mouth, then stomped its feet. Several cracks immediately appeared in the ground, followed by a crashing sound as two wings actually extended from its back - bare of any fur, showing only flesh and bone.

After another roar, the demon beast took to the air. Fragments of stone mixed with turbid qi flew everywhere. Ning Fuyi's heart stirred and she immediately moved forward, but was pulled back by Chu Qingqiu: "Don't be reckless."

"You've never trusted me - how about trusting me just this once!" Ning Fuyi yielded not an inch, her phoenix eyes meeting hers directly. In her urgency, her words actually carried a hint of grievance.

Chu Qingqiu was stunned, and the force in her hands loosened. Ning Fuyi seized the opportunity to grab her arm, leaping up to catch hold of the spikes on the demon beast's back.

Then they soared into the sky.

At the same time, at Copper River.

Dusk was approaching. The fiery sun had already set, leaving only half the sky filled with orange-yellow sunset clouds. From time to time, wild beast howls came from the dense forest, startling flocks of birds that pierced through the clouds.

The ravine on the ground was like a giant, narrow eye - utterly turbid and dark, gazing distantly at the pure azure sky.

"Elder, it's already dark and there's still no movement below. Could Yiyi be..." Liu Wenzhu had cried until her eyelashes stuck together. She wanted to walk forward to look, but was held back by Rong Jin pulling her sleeve.

Rong Jin's condition wasn't much better than hers. He had used both sleeves to wipe away tears until they were soaking wet.

"Front, the front is dangerous. Fuyi has already met with disaster. You must take care of yourself..." he choked out.

"Why cry, cry, cry! What's all this crying!" Qiu Yi on the side shouted irritably. She paced back and forth with her hands behind her back. "My master is down there with her, and my master is Divine Venerable Chu Ling - how could anything happen to her!"

Though she said this, she was also too nervous to stop even for a moment. The grass beneath her feet had been trampled bare.

Although her master had ordered her to stay at the sect, she was truly worried and risked being scolded to follow anyway. Who knew that upon arrival, not only did she not see her master, but she also heard news of Ning Fuyi falling into the ghost eye.

Anyone could figure out with their toes that her master had definitely gone down with her.

"That damned Ning Fuyi only knows how to drag others down. How many injuries has master suffered to save her? When she comes up, I must properly vent my anger!" Qiu Yi couldn't help venting.

"What did you say!" Liu Wenzhu, who had been sobbing, became angry. "Yiyi didn't fall down on purpose! The Divine Venerable kindly saved someone - what right do you have to blame Yiyi!"

"If it weren't for her..."

"Enough, enough!" Rong Jin had a splitting headache. He positioned himself between the two, his eyes red as he said, "Fuyi and the Divine Venerable are still down there with uncertain fates, yet you're arguing here. How heartbreaking for them!"

The two glared at each other and finally closed their mouths - one continuing to trample the innocent grass below, the other continuing to cover her face and weep.

Rong Jin exhaled, suppressing the grief in his heart before walking to Elder Yuan Ming who was equally anxious. He said in a low voice, "Elder, they haven't come out yet. Is there any other way..."

Daoist Yuan Ming vigorously stroked his chin and sighed deeply: "Even the Divine Venerable has no news, so we have even fewer options. I've already sent word to Sect Leader Mei and Elder Pingyao, asking them to send people here while also seeking help from other sects and Penglai Realm to see if anyone can assist."

The sky grew darker and everyone became more anxious. Everyone knew the terror of the ghost eye - once the last ray of sunlight disappeared, those who had fallen would have no way to survive.

Liu Wenzhu had already fallen to her knees, hands clasped together as she prayed to the horizon, begging for Ning Fuyi to escape danger quickly and for the sun to set later.

Though most people had already found their answer in their hearts.

Obviously, prayers were useless. The valley bottom remained silent, and the last trace of sunset glow also faded. The surrounding scenery was covered with a layer of hazy black veil, becoming shadowy and indistinct. The sky showed a clean deep blue - steady and gentle.

Liu Wenzhu's body went limp as she collapsed to the ground, saying nothing, only tears flowing unstopably.

Elder Yuan Ming on the side also turned away, wiping at the corner of his eye with his finger before pulling over the equally ashen-faced Rong Jin, saying gently, "It's dark now, and Copper River is dangerous. Take them back."

Though Rong Jin was grieving, as a senior brother he couldn't lose control like Liu Wenzhu. So he sniffled and walked to Liu Wenzhu's side, dragging and pulling her up: "Wenzhu, let's return to Hibiscus Town first. Qiu Yi..."

"I'm not leaving! If you want to leave, you leave. My master will definitely come out!" Qiu Yi wiped her tear-streaked face and stood against the wind.

Rong Jin couldn't bear it and clenched his palms, supporting Liu Wenzhu as he turned away.

But just as he took one step, strong tremors suddenly came from the ground beneath their feet, as if something was stirring in the earth's crust. Liu Wenzhu nearly couldn't stand steady. She suddenly turned back, tears widening her eyes as she looked toward the ravine.

"Yiyi..." Her words were excited. At the same time as her voice, turbid qi like ocean waves gushed out from the ravine like a volcanic eruption, blowing up trees within dozens of li by their roots. Seeing this, the people present quickly summoned their immortal power, forming shields in front of them.

"It's a demon beast! Fall back quickly!" Elder Yuan Ming shouted sternly upon seeing this. He leaped in front of everyone, spreading both hands as countless vines emerged from the ground to block the turbid qi and the flying sand and stones that followed.

"What is that thing!" Rong Jin was so frightened his voice changed pitch. He quickly summoned his magical weapon - a longbow - aiming at the giant head that soared up from the ravine, but was held back by Liu Wenzhu grabbing his arm.

"Wait, there are people on it," Liu Wenzhu said, not knowing whether to be surprised or delighted. Her grip was so strong it hurt Rong Jin so much he couldn't hold his bow steady. "It's Yiyi! That's Ning Fuyi!!"

"Master!" Qiu Yi was overjoyed and lifted her leg to rush forward, only to be blown back by the wild wind.

In mid-air, the demon beast threw back its head and roared. The sound penetrated the void and entered everyone's ears like several sharp blades cutting through their brains. The pain made their vision go black and their legs go numb as they collapsed one after another.

The people below fell unconscious, and Ning Fuyi on its back wasn't having an easy time either. Her vision could no longer see anything, with only piercing pain pervading her mind. She used her last bit of consciousness to hang onto the demon beast's back.

She felt herself rush into the clouds, then rapidly fall, finally like a mountain collapsing and earth splitting - she could no longer withstand such shaking and released her grip, rolling to the ground.

After a very long time, the world finally quieted, with only the whistling of wind. Ning Fuyi opened her sand-filled eyelids and barely lifted her eyes.

She was lying in a large crater that had been smashed out. At the center of the crater lay the demon beast, though it had now returned to normal form - the size of a tiger, its fur tangled together so one couldn't tell what it actually looked like.

Ping'an was completely unharmed, desperately wagging its tail.

Ning Fuyi gradually became dizzy. She groggily remembered Chu Qingqiu, but there was no sign of Chu Qingqiu in her field of vision. Instead, the demon beast suddenly straightened up and walked toward her step by step.

Ning Fuyi couldn't move. She tensed her body, watching the demon beast open its mouth full of bloody marks toward her. However, following Ping'an's cry, the demon beast stopped its movement.

It seemed very puzzled, tilting its head to look at Ning Fuyi for a long while before suddenly turning around, running with large strides toward the distance and plunging headfirst into the pitch-black mountain forest. Only then did Ning Fuyi's suspended heart settle, and she gradually lost strength.

Her last memory was of Ping'an licking her face. Ning Fuyi smiled and said, "Well done, little thing," then fell into endless darkness.

Time passed minute by minute. When she woke again, she was already on the hard bed of the inn, her chest pressed down by heavy cotton quilts. She took a deep breath, threw off the quilt, and Ping'an bounced up from the floor, jumping on her.

Ning Fuyi touched Ping'an's head. No matter how she looked at it now, it was just an ordinary little white dog, completely unrelated to that terrifying demon beast.

Whether it had mistaken its mother or for some other reason, only by finding that escaped demon beast in the future could she know the answer.

Outside it was already broad daylight, bright sunlight spilling onto the opposite eaves. Several sparrows chirped and hopped on the roof ridge, with rolling distant mountains behind them - a combination of infinite vitality.

Ning Fuyi knew she was still in Hibiscus Town and looked at her body. The wounds left at the valley bottom were completely gone, her skin smooth and delicate, seemingly even better than before. She clicked her tongue twice and sat up cross-legged.

After going through so much trouble to visit Copper River once, she'd gained nothing, and the demon beast had run away too. It really was like fetching water with a bamboo basket - all for nothing. Ning Fuyi laughed self-mockingly, though fortunately she'd managed to save her life.

She still remembered the pink light that had burst forth in her moment of crisis. Though the pink was ugly, that power wasn't insignificant. So she quickly circulated her energy, but after the immortal power made a complete circuit through her body, she found no trace.

The power was very unfamiliar - she'd never seen it in her thousand years of previous life. Where exactly had it come from? And why was it so special? Ning Fuyi stared at the tree shadows on the ground, lost in thought.

Soon, however, knocking interrupted her thoughts.

"Yiyi?" A head poked through the door. Seeing Ning Fuyi sitting up, she smiled brilliantly and entered, placing the clean clothes in her hands down. "Elder Yuan Ming said you'd wake up today. Fortunately, Elder Yuan Ming was here - he specializes in Wood-element magic and is deeply versed in healing arts. In just one night, he completely restored you."

"Wenzhu." Ning Fuyi grinned, making room for her to sit.

She suddenly remembered something and asked, "Where is Divine Venerable Chu Ling? How are her injuries?"

"At this hour, she should be in her room," Liu Wenzhu said, her expression somewhat puzzled. "Injuries? Divine Venerable Chu Ling wasn't injured. Last night when we saw that demon beast, we all fainted. In the end, it was the Divine Venerable who brought us back to Hibiscus Town."

"Fortunately the Divine Venerable was there, otherwise with all of us unconscious, who knows what wild beasts might have carried us off." Liu Wenzhu laughed.

Not injured? How was that possible? Last night Chu Qingqiu had been in such a state, the wound on her chest still vivid in memory. How could she not be injured? Ning Fuyi felt complex emotions - perhaps she didn't want others to know.

But to be so severely injured yet still able to bring everyone back to Hibiscus Town - truly worthy of Chu Qingqiu. She frowned in thought.

"You're actually worried about Divine Venerable Chu Ling." Liu Wenzhu raised her eyebrows, bumping her with her shoulder. "You can rest assured - I saw the Divine Venerable this morning. She's in robust health and was even meditating in the courtyard."

"Who would worry about her?" Ning Fuyi said casually, then stood up and changed into the clean dress Liu Wenzhu had brought - black clothes as usual, clean and neat once worn.

Liu Wenzhu watched her back with a smile, just about to ask what had happened in the ghost eye when suddenly a commotion came from downstairs, as if people were arguing. They could faintly hear Rong Jin's shouts. The two immediately froze and ran downstairs together.

This inn combined guest rooms with a restaurant. Downstairs was the restaurant, where dozens of people were gathered for meals. It was already crowded and noisy, but now it was even more chaotic. A table of food had been overturned on the ground, everyone crowded to the side to watch the excitement, while the waiters stood helplessly aside.

Surrounded by the crowd was indeed Rong Jin. His handsome face was now flushed red, one hand supporting a woman kneeling on the ground who wouldn't get up, the other hand gripping a chair back, looking quite at a loss.

"Senior Brother!" Liu Wenzhu shouted loudly, pushing through the crowd of onlookers to run to his side and stop. "What's the meaning of this?"

Before Rong Jin could speak, the woman kneeling on the ground reached out her other hand to grab Liu Wenzhu, crying to the heavens: "Young master, young lady, I beg you to save my child! This humble woman knows you are immortal masters from Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate. Everyone always says Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate acts chivalrously and saves all beings - you cannot stand by and watch someone die..."

"Please stand up first. There are many people here - shall we stand up and talk?" Liu Wenzhu was soft-hearted and had never seen such a scene. She quickly helped support the woman, touching her wrist.

The woman had no immortal meridians and no other aura about her - just an ordinary mortal.

"If the immortal masters don't agree, this humble woman won't get up. I beg you, save my poor child!" The woman wailed while knocking her head against the ground, frightening Rong Jin and Liu Wenzhu who each grabbed one of her arms. They looked at each other, then toward Ning Fuyi standing outside the crowd.

Ning Fuyi suddenly received their gazes and her mouth twitched.

At the same time, on the top floor of the inn, in the most remote and quiet guest room, waves of tea fragrance wafted out.

For once, the woman wasn't wearing her high-collared long robe but rather white gauze, sitting cross-legged on a mat. This revealed her slender neck, her hair half-pinned up with a jade-white hair crown, with several feather-shaped jade stones hanging from her forehead, swaying gently with her movements.

In this attire, she looked less somber than usual and younger too, though the exposed arms showed how thin her body was.

She was removing murderous aura from colorful crystals on the table, her movements somewhat slow but her expression unchanged.

After a while, footsteps sounded outside the door. Chu Qingqiu didn't look up until the person entered, then said, "Come here."

Hearing this, Qiu Yi quickly brought the tea in her hands, carefully setting it down before kneeling beside Chu Qingqiu: "Master."

"Are these spirit beast cores?" Qiu Yi was startled by the beast cores scattered on the table, exclaiming in shock, "So many, and all from high-level spirit beasts! Master..."

"Leaving them there would be wasteful, so I collected them for use," Chu Qingqiu replied calmly. "After I remove the murderous aura, help me pass them to someone."

Qiu Yi closed her mouth, not daring to say more. Though beast cores were extremely beneficial for cultivation, people generally wouldn't slaughter high-level spirit beasts, so high-level beast cores were very difficult for ordinary people to obtain, let alone so many at once.

She didn't know who could receive such favor from her master. Qiu Yi pouted jealously.

After removing the murderous aura, Chu Qingqiu picked up the beast cores from the table, preparing to put them in a pouch. As she poured the beast cores in, she asked, "Where is Ning Fuyi?"

Qiu Yi touched her head and answered, "Reporting to Master, she's not in the inn."

Chu Qingqiu's eyebrows furrowed, her movements pausing: "We return to the sect tonight. Where did she go?"

"I heard from the waiter downstairs that she went with Liu Wenzhu to some pleasure house, seemingly called Ruyan Tower¹." As Qiu Yi spoke, her cheeks reddened somewhat.

As soon as she finished speaking, a series of clattering sounds could be heard as all the beast cores Chu Qingqiu had been carefully holding fell to the ground.

¹ Ruyan Tower (如烟楼) - Literally "Like Smoke Tower," the name of the brothel/pleasure house.